KHORDQUIZ · START HERE

Passing chords.
One home: C major.

A practical guide to connecting chords with colour, purpose and smooth movement.

The idea in one sentence

A passing or approach chord helps us travel to another chord. It can introduce a note outside C major without making us leave C as our musical home.

HOME

C major

C · D · E · F · G · A · B

C → **A7** → **Dm7** → **G7** → **C**

In this phrase, A7 adds C♯. That note leads into D minor. The phrase continues through G7 and returns to C, so the larger journey still belongs to C major.

Read at your own pace

Your starting point	Suggested pages
New to chords	Pages 2–4: home key, small movements and one complete phrase.
Comfortable with basic chords	Pages 5–9: rootless sounds, chord names and connection tables.
Ready for richer harmony	Pages 10–12: colour chords, practice and clarified instructions.

Review edition · 6 November 2026

This guide records the owner's working connection palette. Standard theory, project naming choices and proposed teaching constraints are identified separately. The final page records clarifications and remaining generation decisions. No quiz content has been changed.

What does “stay in C” mean?

C remains the place where the phrase feels settled—even when another chord briefly gets our attention.

The familiar chords of C major

Degree	Triad	Seventh chord
1 · C	C major	Cmaj7
2 · D	D minor	Dm7
3 · E	E minor	Em7
4 · F	F major	Fmaj7
5 · G	G major	G7
6 · A	A minor	Am7
7 · B	B diminished	Bm7♭5

Three useful words

Diatonic

Every note of the chord belongs to C major. Dm7 contains D–F–A–C, so it is diatonic.

Non-diatonic / chromatic

At least one chord note is outside C major. A7 contains A–C♯–E–G. C♯ is outside the scale, so A7 is non-diatonic.

Tonal centre

The home of the whole phrase. A chord can briefly point toward D minor while the overall phrase still returns naturally to C.

For the proposed five-chord exercises, a useful starting constraint is at least three diatonic chord events and no more than two chromatic events. This is a composition guideline, not a universal law of music. It still needs final approval for generation.

Move the notes, not the whole shape.

Each note is a voice. Keep shared notes where possible and move the others by small distances.

D major → G major

A3	→	B3
F♯3	→	G3
D3	stays	D3

Top row = melody. Bottom row = bass. Play each column together.

A major → D minor

E4	→	F4
C♯4	→	D4
A3	stays	A3

Top row = melody. Bottom row = bass. Play each column together.

What is happening?

Connection	Small movements
D → G	D stays. F♯ rises to G. A rises to B. G major is in second inversion because D is its lowest note.
A → Dm	A stays. C♯ rises to D. E rises to F. D minor is in second inversion because A is its lowest note.

Root, bass and melody are different

The root names the chord. The bass is its lowest sounding note. The melody is its highest sounding note. Changing inversion changes the bass; it does not dictate the melody.

What to avoid in these exercises

Do not move to a distant register merely to put every chord in root position. Root-position movement is not inherently wrong; this exercise deliberately favours nearby voicings so the phrase feels connected.

Try it

Play the left column as one block chord, then the right column. Listen to the top row as a tiny melody. Say the bass note separately. Octave numbers locate the actual keys: C4 is middle C; larger numbers sound higher.

Make a complete musical sentence.

A surprising chord makes more sense when we hear where it is going.

C → **A7** → **Dm7** → **G7** → **Cmaj7**

Chord	Play these notes, low → high	Top note
C	C3 · E3 · G3 · C4	C4
A7	C♯3 · G3 · A3 · E4	E4
Dm7	D3 · F3 · A3 · C4	C4
G7	D3 · F3 · G3 · B3	B3
Cmaj7	C3 · E3 · G3 · B3	B3

Listen for the journey

1. **C establishes home.** The familiar sound gives the phrase a starting point.
2. **A7 adds tension.** Its C♯ points toward D. This is an applied, or secondary, dominant approach.
3. **Dm7 receives the approach.** We have arrived at a chord inside C major, not established a new home key.
4. **G7 leads home.** The phrase prepares its return to C.
5. **Cmaj7 settles the phrase with colour.** Its B is the major seventh, not an added wrong note.

For the chordal-melody quiz

Play all notes of a chord together. The answer follows the highest note of each block: **C4** → **E4** → **C4** → **B3** → **B3**. We are following the top line, not the roots C–A–D–G–C.

The A7 and G7 voicings are inversions. Their roots are still present. These particular voicings illustrate connected movement; they are not the only good choices.

Same notes, different explanations.

A chord’s spelling and context help us understand the sound we are hearing.

A9 without its root

A9
A · C♯ · E · G · B

→

Remove A

→

C♯m7♭5
C♯ · E · G · B

The remaining four notes also form C♯m7♭5. In this project’s named-chord vocabulary, write **C♯m7♭5**. Explain “rootless A9” as a relationship, not as proof that an A root is actually sounding.

Chord	Compact voicing	MIDI, for checking
C♯m7♭5	C♯3 · E3 · G3 · B3	49 · 52 · 55 · 59
Dm7	D3 · F3 · A3 · C4	50 · 53 · 57 · 60

Each voice rises by one or two semitones. This creates a clear approach into Dm7 while preserving a compact register.

The agreed Fm6 / Dm7♭5 naming choice

Use Dm7♭5 consistently

Fm6 and Dm7♭5 share the pitch classes F–A♭–C–D. The owner has chosen the label **Dm7♭5** throughout these new rules. Inversions are allowed; a voicing with F at the bottom is Dm7♭5 in first inversion under this convention.

Replacing a label does not require moving the same four notes to a distant register. In general musical analysis, context can favour a different root interpretation. This is an explicit project convention.

Do not confuse these

Am7♭5 = A–C–E♭–G. Dm7♭5 = D–F–A♭–C. They are different pitch collections and are not interchangeable names.

Read the chord names.

A seventh chord adds a type of seventh to a three-note chord. Altered fifths change the chord’s colour.

Name / symbol	Formula above the root	Example on C
Major · C	1 · 3 · 5	C E G
Minor · Cm	1 · ♭3 · 5	C E♭ G
Diminished · Cdim	1 · ♭3 · ♭5	C E♭ G♭
Augmented · Caug	1 · 3 · ♯5	C E G♯
Major seventh · Cmaj7	1 · 3 · 5 · 7	C E G B
Minor seventh · Cm7	1 · ♭3 · 5 · ♭7	C E♭ G B♭
Dominant seventh · C7	1 · 3 · 5 · ♭7	C E G B♭
Half-diminished · Cm7♭5	1 · ♭3 · ♭5 · ♭7	C E♭ G♭ B♭
Fully diminished · Cdim7	1 · ♭3 · ♭5 · 𝄫7	C E♭ G♭ B𝄫 (sounds A)
Augmented seventh · Caug7	1 · 3 · ♯5 · ♭7	C E G♯ B♭
Minor-major seventh · CmMaj7	1 · ♭3 · 5 · 7	C E♭ G B
Diminished-major · CdimMaj7	1 · ♭3 · ♭5 · 7	C E♭ G♭ B
Dominant seventh flat five · C7♭5	1 · 3 · ♭5 · ♭7	C E G♭ B♭
Major seventh sharp five · Cmaj7♯5	1 · 3 · ♯5 · 7	C E G♯ B
Major seventh flat five · Cmaj7♭5	1 · 3 · ♭5 · 7	C E G♭ B

Two uses of “secondary”

The app’s “secondary seventh chords” is a category of chord qualities. A **secondary dominant** is a harmonic function: for example A7 approaching Dm. These terms do not mean the same thing.

The dictionary explains available names; it does not mean every quality already has approved passing rules. Rootless A9 is taught through C♯m7♭5. No suspended chords or separate minor-sixth labels are included in the new convention.

Triads and major sevenths.

These are the owner's specified routes. The arrow means "may move to", not "must always move to".

Non-diatonic major and minor triads

Approach chord	Destination	How to think about it
D	G	An applied-dominant approach when D leads to G.
E	Am	An applied-dominant approach into the sixth-degree chord.
D	F	A specified chromatic colour connection; not D resolving as G's dominant.
B♭	F	Borrowed colour moving to the fourth-degree chord.
Fm	C	Minor-plagal return to home.
Gm	F	Borrowed minor colour approaching IV.
Gm → Fm	C	Two borrowed minor colours followed by tonic.

Major seventh approaches

Approach chord	Destination
E♭maj7	Dm
A♭maj7	G or G7
B♭maj7	F major · the fourth-degree chord (IV)

Example in C: C → B♭maj7 → F → G7 → C. B♭maj7 approaches IV; the phrase then returns home through G7–C.

Keep C in the frame

A chord pair alone does not establish a whole key. Place it within a phrase that clearly belongs to C. Avoid repeating a local arrival so much that it becomes a new home.

Beginner practice

Start with D–G and E–Am. Find a common note, hold it where possible, then move the remaining voices to the nearest usable chord notes. Add a short diatonic route back to C.

B♭7 is a dominant-seventh quality and appears on the next page, even though it was originally mentioned alongside major-seventh examples.

Dominant and minor sevenths.

The same destination can be approached with different colours. Judge the whole phrase and the actual voices.

Dominant seventh connections

Starting chord	Allowed destination(s)
B♭7	F, Fmaj7, C, Cmaj7 or Am7
C7	F, Fmaj7 or Dm7♭5
B7	G, G7, F, Fmaj7 or Dm7♭5
E7	Am, Am7, A7 or Fmaj7
F7	C
A7	Dm or Dm7♭5

Minor seventh connections

Starting chord	Allowed destination(s)
E♭m7	Dm7
Fm7	C
Gm7	C7 or F♯m7♭5

Function and voice leading are different explanations

E7 → Am is an applied-dominant resolution. A more unusual route such as B7 → F needs a convincing note-by-note explanation in its actual voicing. Do not label every owner-specified route a standard dominant resolution.

Earlier examples also retained

B♭7 → C or Cmaj7 is retained as a borrowed approach to tonic; **B♭7 → Am7** is another owner-specified connection. **G7 → C** remains the ordinary dominant return. Keep the actual voices close and judge each route within the whole phrase.

All former Fm6 destinations have been renamed Dm7♭5 under the project convention. These may be voice-leading or reharmonization choices rather than textbook cadence labels.

Half-diminished and diminished.

Similar names hide an important difference: m7♭5 and dim7 contain different sevenths.

Half-diminished: m7♭5

Starting chord	Allowed destination(s)
C♯m7♭5	Dm7
Dm7♭5	C, Em7♭5 or Am7♭5
Em7♭5	Dm7♭5, A, A7, Am, Fmaj7 or F
Am7♭5	Dm7♭5
Fm7♭5	Em
F♯m7♭5	Fmaj7, Dm7♭5, G7 or F

Fully diminished: dim7

The owner's general device is a dim7 rooted a semitone below the next chord's root. Example: **C♯dim7 → Dm7**. Confirm its actual voice leading; the root relationship alone is not a guarantee.

Specified route	Status
Cdim7 → C	Explicit owner-specified connection.
C♯dim7 → Dm / Dm7 / Dm7♭5 / D7	Semitone-below approach, with different target qualities.
E♭dim7 → C / C7	Explicit connection; not the semitone-below-root pattern.
Edim7 → Dm7 / Dm7♭5 / D7	Explicit connection; not the semitone-below-root pattern.
Fdim7 → F♯m7♭5	Semitone-below approach.
Fdim7 → C	Confirmed return after FmMaj7 → FdimMaj7 → Fdim7.

Use the effect sparingly

The owner's limit is **one fully diminished seventh chord event per sequence**. This counts dim7, not dimMaj7. A sequence containing CdimMaj7 → Cdim7 uses one fully diminished event.

Targets in the general rule may be major/minor triads, maj7, min7, dom7 or m7♭5. No target automatically changes the home key; the complete phrase still needs a C-major frame.

Diminished-major and altered major sevenths.

Treat these as carefully voiced colour connections, not universal replacements for simpler chords.

Starting chord	Recorded destination(s)
CdimMaj7	Cdim7 → Dm7 preferred; Cdim7 may also lead to Fmaj7 or Am7.
E♭dimMaj7	Dm7
FdimMaj7	Em7, C or Fdim7
B♭dimMaj7	Am7 or Fmaj7
FmMaj7	Em7, C, Cmaj7 or Am7; also FdimMaj7 → Fdim7 → C.
A♭mMaj7	C, Cmaj7 or Fm7♭5
Cmaj7♭5	B♭maj7 (confirmed); Dm7 was also specified earlier.
D♭maj7♭5	C or Cmaj7
E♭maj7♭5	Dm or Dm7
Fmaj7♭5	Em, C or Cmaj7
A♭maj7♭5	Dm7♭5 → C, as provisionally understood.
B♭maj7♭5	F or Fmaj7

One of the owner's concrete voicings

B♭dimMaj7 → **Fmaj7**

Chord	Actual keys, low → high	Written explanation
B♭dimMaj7	B♭3 · D♭4 · E4 · A4	Spell the E as F♭ in the chord formula: B♭–D♭–F♭–A.
Fmaj7	C4 · E4 · F4 · A4	A stays; the lower voices move upward by 2, 3 and 1 semitones.

The example stays in a neighbouring register. It briefly reaches A4; the earlier proposed C3–C5 range includes it. Retain the exact note placement when demonstrating this example.

Aug7, dom7♭5 and maj7♯5 are named in the vocabulary, but their specific new movement rules have not yet been supplied.

Build a phrase you can explain.

Start simple. Make the connection sound natural before adding another colour.

1. **Choose a destination inside C major.** Start with Dm, F or G. Know where your phrase is going.
2. **Choose one approach from the palette.** Try A7 before Dm7, or Fm before C. Read the full connection, not just one chord name.
3. **Place the voices close together.** Keep shared notes where practical. Listen to bass and top line separately.
4. **Complete the five-chord phrase.** Give the approach enough context for C to remain home. A final C or Cmaj7 is a useful teaching constraint, not a law for every musical phrase.
5. **Play all five blocks.** Can you sing the highest notes? Does the final arrival feel connected to what came before?
6. **Check the actual pitches.** The name, bass/inversion and highest note must agree with the keys being played.

Questions for the learner

Beginner

In A–Dm, which note stays? Which chord contains C♯? In the worked five-chord phrase on page 4, sing only the top notes.

Intermediate

Explain why A7 is outside C major but Dm7 is inside it. Play C♯m7♭5 → Dm7. Then play Dm7♭5 → C using nearby voicings.

Advanced

Voice B♭dimMaj7 → Fmaj7 exactly as shown, then find another compact inversion pair. Explain each voice movement without pretending the connection is a standard V–I.

Answer hints: A is held in the page-3 A–Dm example. C♯ belongs to A major/A7, not to the diatonic C-major scale. Standard applied-dominant language fits A7–Dm; uncommon colour routes need their own voice-leading explanation.

Clarifications and teaching choices.

Keep the teaching core clear. Do not silently turn unclear dictation into a new musical rule.

Clarifications now recorded

Earlier unclear wording	Owner's clarification
Em7♭5 → Em7♭5	Use Em7♭5 → Dm7♭5. Dm7♭5 → Am7♭5 was also added.
Am7♭5 → "minor six"	Am7♭5 → Dm7♭5.
Minor-major → "diminished minor"	FmMaj7 → FdimMaj7 → Fdim7 → C.
FmMaj7 → "E"	FmMaj7 → Em7.
Cmaj7♭5 → "D. B-flat major seven"	Cmaj7♭5 → B♭maj7, not B♭dimMaj7.
A♭maj7♭5 → Fm6 / Dm7♭5 → C	The earlier interpretation remains Dm7♭5 → C, using the approved naming convention; no new clarification was supplied.

The generated 100-candidate review collection separately flags two six-event chains with three chromatic events: FmMaj7–FdimMaj7–Fdim7–C and Dm7♭5–Am7♭5–Dm7♭5–C. Their full chains cannot fit a strict diatonic majority in six events.

Generation proposals—not yet a final brief

Five chords per new sequence; a mostly diatonic C-major frame; compact voicings; no more than one dim7 event; no suspended chords; and the agreed Dm7♭5 naming. The earlier suggestions of at least three diatonic events, a final C/Cmaj7 and the exact register/leap limits still need final approval against the expanded palette.

Further reading

The explanations here are original teaching text based on the owner's palette. Standard background on applied dominants and borrowed harmony was checked against Open Music Theory. These sources do not endorse every custom connection in the tables.

Open Music Theory · Tonicization
Open Music Theory · Modal Mixture

Before publishing or adding quiz questions

Confirm any remaining teaching constraints, check every chord formula and actual voicing, then listen to the full phrase. A mathematically valid note set is not, by itself, proof of a convincing musical phrase.